

VEER

# Learning Something New

---

A language, an instrument, a skill you gave up on. The patient tutor you never had.

# You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

---

**Be taught, not told** — the difference, and how to ask for it.

---

**Start from genuinely nothing** without pretending you know things you don't.

---

**Get an explanation three different ways** until one of them lands.

---

**Practise a language out loud** with something that never gets impatient.

---

**Be corrected** without being discouraged.

---

**Test yourself properly**, which is the part almost everyone skips.

---

**Get past week three**, where most attempts quietly stop.

You'll need a subject. Have one in mind before you start — anything you've meant to learn and haven't.

## 01

# The tutor who never sighs

Think about why adults stop learning things.

Rarely because it was too hard. Usually because asking felt worse than not knowing. You'd have to admit you didn't understand something you feel you should, to a person, possibly more than once, and the fourth time you ask you can hear the patience going out of their voice.

**That constraint has gone.** You can ask the same question eleven times, in slightly different words, at midnight, and the eleventh answer is as patient as the first.

This matters more than any technique in this book. Most adult learning fails at the point of embarrassment, not the point of difficulty.

**Which means the useful instruction is: say how little you know.**

Not as an apology — as information.

#### THE HONEST OPENER

I want to learn about this and I know genuinely nothing. Assume I don't know any of the vocabulary. Start with what the thing actually is and why anyone does it, before any detail.

#### SAY THE EMBARRASSING PART

"I've nodded along about this for years and never actually understood it" is one of the most useful sentences you can type. It gets you the explanation you needed rather than the one you pretended not to need.

**Try this now.** Name the thing you've been nodding along about.

Ask what it actually is.

## 02

## Explain it like I've never done this

The default explanation is pitched at someone who half-knows the subject already. That's no use, and the fix is to say who you are.

### Three things change every explanation:

---

**What you actually know.** "I've never done this" or "I did it at school thirty years ago" are different starting points.

---

**What comparison would help.** Ask for it to be explained in terms of something you *do* understand.

---

**What you want to do with it.** Learning to cook for a family is a different curriculum from learning to cook to impress.

## THE ONE THAT WORKS

Explain how a mortgage actually works. I've never had one and I don't know any of the terminology. Use a comparison from everyday life, and stop after each part to check I've followed before moving on.

**"Stop and check" is the phrase that turns a lecture into teaching.** Without it you get an essay. With it you get a conversation where the next part depends on whether you understood the last one.

**If it doesn't land, say so specifically.** Not "I don't understand" — *I followed until the bit about interest, and then you lost me.* The specific version gets you a targeted second attempt.

**Try this now.** Ask for something explained with "stop after each part to check I've followed."

## 03

## Starting from nothing

The hardest part of any new subject is that you can't tell what to learn first. Beginners' guides assume a beginner who already knows what the parts are called.

**Ask for the path before the content.**

### THE PATH ASK

I want to learn to play the piano. I have no musical background and can't read music. I can practise twenty minutes a day. Give me the first four weeks — what to work on each week and roughly when I'd expect it to start feeling less impossible.

Twenty minutes a day is the honest constraint, and it changes the plan completely.

**Ask what to ignore.** Every subject has advice aimed at people three years ahead of you. *What can I safely ignore for now?* is as valuable as what to learn.

**Ask what the first real milestone is.** Something you can *do*, not something you'll know. One song, one conversation, one loaf. Milestones you can perform are the ones that keep you going.

ASK FOR THE SMALLEST FIRST STEP

"What's the smallest thing I could do today that would count as starting?"  
Twenty minutes today beats a perfect plan you begin next month, and it's the single most effective question in this book.

**Try this now.** Ask for your four weeks. Then do the smallest first step today.

## 04

## Practising out loud

For languages especially, the thing standing between people and progress is having someone patient to practise with, at your level, whenever you have twenty minutes.

**Ask for a conversation at your level, on a subject you'd actually encounter.**

### LANGUAGE PRACTICE

Let's have a conversation in Spanish. I'm a beginner — about six weeks in. Play a waiter in a café. Keep your sentences short, correct me gently as we go, and if I get stuck, give me the word in English and let me try again.

Naming the level and the situation is what stops it opening with a sentence you can't parse.

**Ask it to slow down or speed up.** *That was slightly too easy* is useful information. So is *too fast, go back a level*.

**Ask for the correction after, not during.** Constant interruption kills the flow; a summary at the end of what you kept getting wrong is more useful and less demoralising.

**This works beyond languages.** Rehearse an interview, a viva, a difficult explanation, a pitch. Anything where the skill is producing something out loud under mild pressure.

#### THE HONEST LIMIT

It won't hear your accent or your fingering. For anything physical — pronunciation, an instrument, a craft — you'll eventually need a person or a recording of yourself. This gets you a long way, and not the whole way.

**Try this now.** Have a five-minute conversation at your actual level. Not the level you wish you were.

## 05

# Being corrected without being put off

Correction is where adult learning usually dies. Too gentle and you don't improve; too blunt and you stop.

**You can specify this, which almost nobody realises.**

## SETTING THE TONE

When you correct me, tell me what was wrong and why, but keep it brief and don't apologise for correcting me. I'd rather be corrected properly than encouraged.

## IF YOU'RE FRAGILE ABOUT IT

I'm finding this discouraging. Correct the things that matter most and let the small ones go for now. Tell me what I'm getting right as well.

Both are legitimate. The second is not a lesser setting — a beginner drowning in corrections gives up, and a beginner who gives up learns nothing.

**Ask for the pattern, not the instances.** Ten individual corrections are noise. *What am I getting wrong repeatedly?* is a lesson.

**Ask what to fix first.** Errors aren't equal. *Which of my mistakes actually gets in the way of being understood, and which are cosmetic?*

THE QUESTION THAT SHORTENS EVERYTHING

"What's the one habit I should break first?" Most learners have a single systematic error producing many symptoms. Finding it early saves months.

**Try this now.** Ask what you've been getting wrong repeatedly. Ask which one to fix first.

## 06

## When you're stuck on one thing

Sometimes the whole subject is fine except for one piece that won't go in. You've read it four times. You've watched a video. It still doesn't sit.

**Say precisely where the understanding stops.**

### THE STUCK ASK

I understand everything up to this point, and then it stops making sense. Here's my current understanding, including the part I think might be wrong. Find the misunderstanding rather than explaining the whole thing again.

**Including your wrong version is the trick.** A misconception is much easier to correct than an absence, and repeating the same correct explanation louder never works.

## Ask for a completely different angle.

### WHEN REPETITION ISN'T WORKING

Explain that a completely different way. If you used an analogy, use a concrete example instead. If you started with the theory, start with what it's used for.

**Ask what's usually confusing about it.** *What do people commonly misunderstand here?* often names your exact problem, and it's oddly reassuring to learn it's a known trap rather than a personal failing.

**Ask what you're missing underneath.** Sometimes the block is a gap two steps earlier that nobody flagged.

**Try this now.** Take your stuck point. Write your wrong version. Ask it to find the fault.

## 07

## Testing yourself

The part everyone skips, and the one that decides whether any of this stuck.

Re-reading feels like learning and mostly isn't. Being asked, and failing, and finding out — that's the bit that works, and it's uncomfortable, which is why people avoid it.

### THE QUIZ

Quiz me on what we've covered. One question at a time, wait for my answer, and don't tell me if I'm right until I've committed to an answer.

**"One at a time" and "wait" matter.** A list of ten questions gets skimmed. One question you have to answer gets thought about.

**Ask it to come back to what you got wrong.** *Ask me again about the ones I missed, later in the session.*

**Ask for questions that need explaining, not recalling.** *Ask me to explain why, not to name what.* Explaining is where you find out whether you actually understand.

**Ask it to notice the pattern.** *After the quiz, tell me what my wrong answers have in common.*

THE BEST TEST THERE IS

"Let me explain this back to you, and tell me what I've got wrong or missed."  
Explaining something badly is the fastest way to discover you don't know it —  
and this is a listener with unlimited patience for a bad explanation.

**Try this now.** Explain something you've been learning, badly, and ask what you missed.

## 08

## Getting past week three

Honest lesson to end on.

Most attempts to learn something stop at around week three. Not from difficulty — from the disappearance of visible progress. Week one everything is new. By week three you're grinding and the improvement has gone underground.

Nothing in this book prevents that. What follows helps.

**Ask for evidence you've improved.** *Here's what I could do four weeks ago and here's what I can do now — what's actually changed?* Progress you can't see is still progress, and having it named is often enough.

**Lower the bar deliberately.** *I've got ten minutes and no energy.*

*What's worth doing?* A ten-minute session keeps the habit alive; a skipped one starts the slide.

**Change the activity, not the subject.** If drills have gone stale, ask for something applied. Boredom is usually the format, not the interest.

**Ask what's normal.** *Is it usual to plateau at this stage?* It nearly always is, and knowing that is the difference between "this is a phase" and "I'm not cut out for this."

#### THE ONE TO KEEP

"Remind me why I wanted to learn this." It sounds soft. It's the most practical question in the book, because the reason is what carries you through the weeks where the progress doesn't show.

**Try this now.** Write down why you want to learn this thing. Keep it. Week three is coming.

# Your four-week starter path

Fill this in for your own subject, in your own words. Ask for each piece as you reach it.

**Before you start** — *I want to learn this and I know nothing. What is it, why do people do it, and what should I ignore for now?*

**Week 1 — the smallest first step.** *What's the smallest thing I could do today that counts as starting?* Do that today, not tomorrow.

**Week 1 — the first milestone.** *What's the first thing I'll be able to do, and roughly when?* Something you can perform, not something you'll know.

**Week 2 — the honest plan.** *I have twenty minutes a day. What should I work on each week for the next four?*

**Week 2 — practise out loud.** Set the level, set the scene, ask to be corrected gently.

---

**Week 3 — find the pattern.** *What am I getting wrong repeatedly, and which one should I fix first?*

---

**Week 3 — the plateau.** *Is it usual to stop feeling progress at this stage?*  
Yes. Keep going.

---

**Week 4 — test yourself.** *Quiz me, one question at a time, and don't tell me if I'm right until I've answered.*

---

**Week 4 — the evidence.** *Here's what I could do four weeks ago and what I can do now. What's changed?*

---

# When it goes wrong

**"It's explaining above my head."** You haven't said how little you know. Say it plainly, and ask it to assume no vocabulary at all.

**"It gives me an essay when I wanted a conversation."** Add *stop after each part and check I've followed*. That one clause changes the whole behaviour.

**"The language practice is too hard."** Name your level in weeks or months, not as "beginner." Six weeks in and two years in are both beginners.

**"It keeps praising me and I can't tell if I'm improving."** Ask for correction without encouragement, and ask specifically what you're getting wrong repeatedly.

**"I asked it to quiz me and it gave me the answers."** Add *wait for my answer before telling me if I'm right*. It defaults to being helpful, and helpful is the opposite of a test.

**"It told me something about the subject that was wrong."** It can be. In a subject you're learning you're least able to catch it — so for facts that matter, check against a real source, and treat it as the patient explainer rather than the authority. *Is This Safe?* covers this properly.

**"I've stopped and I feel bad about it."** Extremely common and not a verdict. Ask for the smallest possible restart — one ten-minute session, no plan, no catching up. The path back in is always smaller than the one you imagine.

#### THE PATTERN

Nearly every problem here is fixed by saying more about yourself: how little you know, how long you've been at it, how much time you have, and how you want to be corrected.

# If you only do one thing

Take one habit and leave the other seven.

**Make it check whether you followed.**

Add *stop after each part and check I've understood before moving on* to any explanation, and *wait for my answer before telling me if I'm right* to any quiz.

Both do the same thing: they stop it performing knowledge at you and make it find out what's actually in your head. That's the entire difference between reading about something and being taught it — and it's the thing no book, video or article has ever been able to do for you.

You now have a tutor who will do it at eleven at night, for the eleventh time, without sighing.

# Do this next

**Helping a child learn rather than yourself? → Family Life** — the homework script that tutors instead of answering, with a clear line about what never gets handed in.

**Worried it might be teaching you something wrong? → Is This Safe?** — why it's sometimes confidently wrong, and how to check without checking everything.

**Want your requests to land first time? → Asking Better Questions** — the four things that turn a generic answer into a useful one.

**Ideas across the rest of life? → 101 Everyday Things to Ask Claude.**

*The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.*

## DISCLAIMER

This is an independent educational guide created by Veer. It is not affiliated with, authorized by, sponsored by, or endorsed by Anthropic PBC. "Claude" and "Anthropic" are trademarks of Anthropic PBC, used here for identification and descriptive purposes only. All product features, model names, pricing, and interfaces described are those of Anthropic and are subject to change; verify current details at the official source.

This guide reflects the author's own methods and opinions. Nothing in it is professional instruction, and it is not a substitute for a qualified teacher, particularly for anything physical or anything where poor technique causes injury. An assistant can explain and quiz you; it cannot see or hear you, and it can be confidently wrong about matters of fact — check anything that matters against a reliable source.

© 2026 Veer. Personal-use license — for your own use; please don't redistribute or resell.